

Research activities

- 1 Read Arrian's assessment of Alexander's right to claim the title 'the Great' on p157.
 - What factors make someone great?
 - What aspects of Alexander's personality made him great according to Arrian?
 - What were his achievements according to Arrian?
 - What were his setbacks and mistakes according to Arrian?
 - Does Alexander deserve the title— 'the Great'?
- 2 List the changes Alexander tried to introduce that upset the Macedonians.
 - Why did the Macedonian nobility and the Greeks resent these changes?
 - Imagine that you are Alexander the Great talking to a group of Macedonian nobles and Greeks. Explain why you were trying to introduce the Persian customs.
- 3 Read Arrian's *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 4.10 ; 7.29–30 and Plutarch's *Life of Alexander*, 54.
 - According to Arrian why did Alexander want to introduce the custom of proskynesis?
 - Why do you think he wanted to introduce this custom?
 - According to Plutarch how did Callisthenes upset Alexander?
- 4 Read Arrian's *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 4.8–9 and Plutarch's *Life of Alexander*, 50–2 on the murder of Cleitus.
 - Describe the event as told by both historians. Are there any differences in the accounts?
 - According to these sources, what effects did this event have on Alexander?

Alexander's growing arrogance and orientalised. These people were insulted to think that they, as conquerors, were now being asked to adopt 'barbarian customs'.

Alexander also introduced Persian youths (30 000 of them) into the army, training them in the use of the Macedonian arms and tactics. He also appointed Persians as satraps and officials in the government.

Attempts were made to encourage leading Macedonians and Greeks to accept the changes. Hephaestion joined Alexander while others like Craterus grew more unhappy. In 330BC an attempt to assassinate Alexander was supposedly discovered. Philotas, one of the leading Macedonian officers was implicated; tried on little evidence and executed. His father Parmenio, one of Alexander's leading generals, was assassinated at the same time. AB Bosworth suggests that Alexander's attempts to introduce Persian customs was an obvious change from Macedonian tradition, which angered the older and conservative members of the Macedonian aristocracy.

The introduction of proskynesis

Possibly the most misunderstood custom that Alexander tried to introduce to his court was that of proskynesis, or prostration. To the Persians this was a gesture of respect performed by all to the Great King, whom they did not regard as a god; it was not a sign of worship. Unfortunately, both Greeks and Macedonians saw it as an act performed when worshipping a god and many bitterly resented prostrating themselves to a man. Alexander's reasons for introducing this custom are not clear. Perhaps it was to show that Persians and Macedonians held equal positions within his government. Perhaps it was, as some sources suggest, to encourage the notion of Alexander as a god. Whatever the reason, it failed. One of its chief critics was Callisthenes, the official historian of the expedition, who had been one of Alexander's main supporters.

The murder of Cleitus

Cleitus had saved Alexander's life at Granicus but had grown unhappy with the changes being made (327BC). According to the sources, both Cleitus and Alexander were drunk, they argued about the Macedonian resentment to the changes, and eventually in a fit of rage he was killed by Alexander. After the event Alexander was distraught and stayed in his tent for three days without food to repent his actions. O'Brien has suggested that this incident is evidence of Alexander's increasingly megalomaniacal streak.

The Conspiracy of the Pages

In 327BC a group of young Macedonians, led by Hermolaus, unsuccessfully plotted to kill Alexander. Callisthenes was implicated in the plot. He was arrested and either executed or died in custody.

These significant events indicated the extent of Macedonian opposition to Alexander's changes. These incidents were far more serious threats to Alexander's leadership than the mutinies of the army had been.

Long-lasting achievements?

Alexander's death in 323BC left the empire with no clear successor. His wife Roxane was pregnant and one of the generals, Perdiccas, suggested that no decision be made until the child was born. If it was a boy then a regent would be appointed until he was old enough to rule. These plans never came to be. The generals began to divide the empire, and fought between themselves for the next 150 years until the Romans established their control over much of the area. The main kingdoms that were established were the Seleucid (based in Syria), the Ptolemaic (in Egypt) and the Antigonid (based in Macedonia).

Whether intentionally or not, Alexander's establishment of cities and his conquest of the Persian Empire meant that Greek ideas and customs spread throughout the Near East.